London Ambulance Service NHS
NHS Trust

Poisons

Component 5

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Objective

Describe the types of poisons and causes.

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Definition of a Poison

" Exposure… of a substance(s) that may result in mortality or morbidity"

The cause of poisoning is when the quantity of a substance becomes so great is causes death.

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Poisoning may be intentional, accidental or non-accidental

Poisons may enter the body by:

1. **Inhalation** (e.g. gases or fumes)
2. **Ingestion** (e.g. liquids or solids)
3. **Injection** (e.g. needles or bites)
4. **Absorption** (e.g. through eyes or skin)

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Common Types of Poison

- Household products
- Pharmaceutical / recreational substances
- Plants / fungi
- Alcohol
- Chemicals
- Cosmetics

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Assessment of the poisoned patient

- Primary Survey
- History
- Evaluate if **TIME CRITICAL**
- Begin appropriate treatment and gain advice where required
- Transport to further care

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Principles of treatment

Management should be based on:

- Identification of poisons
- Specific treatment for specific poisons
- Rapid access to hospital

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Carbon monoxide

- Consider if patient is in a confined space with impaired ventilation or boiler may be defective



- **Remove patient from source**
- **Administer continuous high concentration oxygen (SPO2 monitoring has no value in this situation)**

S+S – Disorientated, reduced consciousness / unconscious

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Table 3.103 – Signs and Symptoms of Carbon Monoxide Poisoning

Acute low-level exposure	Acute high-level exposure	Chronic low-level exposure
• Headache • Dizziness • Nausea • Vomiting • General lethargy	• Headache • Dizziness • Nausea • Vomiting • Lethargy • Muscle ataxia • Confusion • Chest pains • Shortness of breath/difficulty in breathing • Neurological deficit • Coma	• Headache • Dizziness • Nausea • Vomiting • General lethargy • Flu-like symptoms • Neurological decline • Visual problems

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Table 3.104 – Questions to Be Asked in Cases of Carbon Monoxide Poisoning [17], [18]	
Cohabitants/companions	Does anyone else feel unwell? Are any pets behaving abnormally?
Outdoors	Do you feel better if you go outside or when you are away from the property for a prolonged time?
Maintenance	Are any heating appliances properly maintained?
Alarms	Do you have a working CO alarm? Has it activated?

Further specific advice on poisons and substances can be found in JRCalc +

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Any Questions?

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